

Rebranding Nashville Through its Most Famous Icon

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In the early morning hours of March 3, 2020, a momentous photo began circulating the web (fig. 1). It showed, under cloudy skies tinted orange by the approaching daybreak, the facade of The Basement East, the beloved music venue of East Nashville, reduced to rubble following an EF-3 tornado that cost 25 lives and over \$1.5 billion in damages.¹ But it also showed one small section of the facade that stood tall through the harrowing night. It was the section that featured the “I Believe in Nashville” mural, a simple, memorable, tri-colored rectangular icon. The Tennessee state flag tristar anchors the center, red and white stripes form the background, and the text, “I Believe in Nashville,” encases the symbol, imitating the font and style of what might have been seen on a patriotic American propaganda poster from the First World War. For the twister to spare this mural despite annihilating its surroundings led residents and people online to credit the phenomenon as nothing short of divine messaging. One Nashville resident wrote on X (formerly Twitter), “I’ll be honest, I tend not to believe in God. But I must say the fact that the Believe in #Nashville mural survived when the building didn’t feels like a sign. This city is strong.”²

Over the next few months, the photo frequently headlined articles about Nashville’s redevelopment, receiving attention from *The Tennessean*, CNN, *Rolling Stone*, *People Magazine*, and even country music legend Tim McGraw.³ After the disaster, more than ever, people saw the mural as an emblem of Nashville’s redevelopment, resilience, and unity.

¹ Karen Grigsby, “20 things to know about the 2010 Nashville flood,” *The Tennessean*, last modified May 3, 2016, <https://www.tennessean.com/story/news/local/2015/04/30/nashville-flood-20-things-to-know/26653901/>.

² Alicia Lee, “An iconic mural is still standing after a tornado ripped through a Nashville neighborhood,” *CNN*, published March 3, 2020, <https://www.cnn.com/2020/03/03/us/nashville-tornado-mural-trnd/index.html>.

³ Matthew Leimkuehler & Dave Paulson, “Basement East destroyed by Nashville tornado, but ‘I Believe in Nashville’ mural remains,” *The Tennessean*, last modified March 4, 2020, <https://www.tennessean.com/story/news/2020/03/03/nashville-tornadoes-i-believe-nashville-mural-basement-east-damage/4937484002/>; Joseph Hudak, “Nashville Venue Destroyed by Tornado,” *Rolling Stone*, published March 3, 2020, <https://www.rollingstone.com/music/music-country/nashville-tornado-basement-east-damage-961184/>;

But this does not reflect how one would usually encounter the "I Believe in Nashville" mural online. These images of East Nashville's destruction are far outnumbered by the thousands of photos and selfies of mostly young white women dressed in stereotypical southern fashion, posing in front of the same mural in the 12 South neighborhood, the original location of "I Believe in Nashville." First painted in 2012, in just the few years it has been around, this mural and its imitations have become one of Nashville's most famous cultural icons, with 10,000 followers on the official "I Believe in Nashville" Instagram page and nearly 60,000 posts with the #ibelieveinnashville tag.⁴ The mural has been parodied in California and Florida, publicized in GQ Magazine and The Wall Street Journal, and featured on shirts worn by multiple celebrities.⁵ "I Believe in Nashville" has come to refer to far more than just a mural, but has also become a cultural symbol, digital icon, and saleable product.

New meanings of "I Believe in Nashville" begin to take shape when considering who propagates the icon and how and where these interactions take place. While widely publicized public art has the capacity to move a public to action, the extreme popularity of "I Believe in Nashville" instead simultaneously masks and perpetuates issues that have arisen out of Nashville's unprecedented growth since the turn of the century. This mural has also become a convenient rallying cry that allows the public to avoid confrontation with these uncomfortable truths. "I Believe in Nashville," though unprovocative in itself, partakes in a provocative

Mackenzie Schmidt, "Beloved 'I Believe in Nashville' Mural Barely Escapes Destruction by Tennessee Tornado," *People*, published March 4, 2020, <https://people.com/travel/beloved-i-believe-in-nashville-mural-barely-escapes-destruction-by-tennessee-tornado/>;

Tim McGraw (@TheTimMcGraw), "The iconic 'I Believe In Nashville' murals started popping up after the big flood ten years ago," Tweet, March 3, 2020, <https://twitter.com/TheTimMcGraw/status/1234896418411884544>.

⁴ (@ibelieveinnashville), *Instagram Page*, <https://www.instagram.com/ibelieveinnashville/>; "#ibelieveinnashville", *Instagram Hashtag*, <https://www.instagram.com/explore/tags/ibelieveinnashville/?hl=en>.

⁵ I Believe in Nashville, "Happy Birthday Mamba," Facebook Post, August 23, 2020, https://www.facebook.com/IBelieveInNashville/photos_by;

Alfs, "'I Believe in Nashville' muralist goes global."

relationship with its environment. For these murals that claim to be owned by all of Nashville, their specific locations in neighborhoods that have a history of driving out their black communities, in addition to their exploitation and circulation by a predominantly white public, imbue “I Believe in Nashville” with a new layer of meaning rooted in racist ideals, predatory capitalism, and postmodern social practices.

This essay posits three main understandings of the mural. First, as a monument to the heroic resilience and growth of a booming city. Second, as a monument to “New Nashville,” a city that exploits its own culture to tourists and outside developers at the expense of locals’ quality of life. Finally, as a superficial postmodern icon that gives the impression of a unified public while also signaling an increasingly divided and commercialized society. Taking into account Nashville’s rapid change over the last twenty years, “I Believe in Nashville” takes on a range of meanings depending on the time and context. But one major trend seems certain as the city continues to expand at astonishing speed. Nashville is losing the small town charm that first captivated residents who moved here decades ago, and the city now grapples with crises over gentrification, its identity, and its culture. This paper argues that the ways in which the public has received, replicated, parodied, and commodified “I Believe in Nashville” both reflects and perpetuates an especially Nashvilian tradition of falsifying its own identity to rebrand itself for growth. “I Believe in Nashville” becomes a tool to mask and distract the public from Nashville’s issues. As tourists ravage the town and transform Nashville into an unrecognizable landscape, and as locals bemoan their evolving neighborhoods as the last remnants of their old town get sold off to private developers, the question arises: Who actually believes in Nashville?

A Monument to Triumph

Local artist Adrien Saporiti painted the first “I Believe in Nashville” mural in 2012 on the wall of a decrepit, gutted building in the developing 12 South neighborhood. At the time, Nashville was recovering from the immense losses of the catastrophic floods from two years prior, a once-in-a-millennium event that displaced 10,000 residents, cost \$2 billion, and left 26 dead.⁶ 12 South, like most of Nashville, was in the midst of rapidly rebuilding its infrastructure and image. Despite the enormous level of destruction, the redevelopment process was lauded for being smooth, efficient, organized, and a mostly unassisted effort by the people of Nashville. Overshadowed by events like the Deepwater Horizon Oil Spill and a foiled car bombing at Times Square, the floods went relatively unnoticed by the national media.⁷ Nashville native Margaret Renkl wrote in a *Times* article about how the national public views such tragedies that happen in *this* part of “flyover country” as somehow being self-afflicted and unnoteworthy.⁸ This lack of attention had even been turned into an art exhibit at the Frist, titled, “Nobody Cared When Nashville Drowned.”⁹

Yet Nashville rebuilt, even bigger than ever.¹⁰ In 2013, just three years after the flood, the *Times* crowned Nashville the “it” city of America — a title that usually lasts only a few years, but one that Nashville has not seemed to shake off even 10 years later.¹¹ In the past decade,

⁶ “May 2010 Flood,” *National Weather Service*, <https://www.weather.gov/ohx/may2010flood>; Alicia Patton, “PHOTOS: 12 year anniversary of historic Nashville 2010 flood,” *WKRN*, May 1, 2022, <https://www.wkrn.com/news/local-news/nashville/photos-12-year-anniversary-of-historic-nashville-2010-flood/#:~:text=NASHVILLE%2C%20Tenn.,and%20leaving%2018%20people%20dead>.

⁷ Margaret Renkl, “Nobody Cared When Nashville Drowned,” *The New York Times*, January 20, 2020, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/01/20/opinion/2010-nashville-flood.html>.

⁸ *Ibid.*

⁹ “Nobody Cared When Nashville Drowned — The Nashville Flood: Ten Years Later,” *Frist Art Museum*, 2020, <https://fristartmuseum.org/resource/nobody-cared-when-nashville-drowned-the-nashville-flood-ten-years-later/>

¹⁰ Blake Farmer, “After Floods, Nashville Proud Of Model Recovery,” *NPR*, May 1, 2011, <https://www.npr.org/2011/05/01/135891307/after-floods-nashville-proud-of-model-recovery>. FEMA even cites Nashville as a model city for recovery.

¹¹ Kim Severson, “Nashville’s Latest Big Hit Could Be the City Itself,” *The New York Times*, January 8, 2013, <https://www.nytimes.com/2013/01/09/us/nashville-takes-its-turn-in-the-spotlight.html>.

Nashville has enjoyed tremendous outside investment, welcoming new corporate offices for Oracle, Amazon and AllianceBernstein. The city even got its own hit TV show, *Nashville*.¹²

Saporiti had not seen any of this yet, but he did see a wrecked city uniting together after an overlooked national tragedy, which inspired him to paint the first “I Believe in Nashville” mural (fig. 2). He wanted to capture an inspirational moment that “showed our resiliency, our resolve, and our strength and ability to come together.”¹³ In this way, “I Believe in Nashville” was a monument to solidarity in times of tragedy and a testament to the unwavering faith and pride of a self-sufficient city, a sense of pride that no doubt strengthened after the outstanding disaster effort. As mentioned earlier, this understanding reached a much wider audience following the 2021 floods.

From the American stripes the blocky font, “I Believe in Nashville” exudes Americana, an aesthetic that is firmly rooted in the previous century, reminiscent of antique American propaganda posters.¹⁴ The mural appears historical, yet is both a contemporary creation and responds to a contemporary event. The mural gives the impression that it has been there much longer than it actually has, that it has somehow seen the highs and lows of Nashville’s exciting past from that very wall, and that it originated from a charged past and was preserved all the way through the present day because of its inseparability from Nashville’s history and identity. Barring the small “© 2012” under the mural, all the aspects of the mural seem to reference a history that does not actually exist.

¹² Brittany Hodak, “The Real-Life Impact of ABC’s ‘Nashville,’” *Forbes*, October 28, 2015, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/brittanyhodak/2015/10/28/the-real-life-impact-of-abcs-nashville/?sh=6eedf03e1e2d>. A study also found that 1 in 5 Nashville tourists said the show was a factor in their decision to visit, and tourists also spent more time and 23% more money while in town.

¹³ Alison Bonaguro, “The Man Behind The ‘I Believe in Nashville’ Mural,” *CMT*, March 5, 2020, <https://www.cmt.com/news/gfkgst/the-man-behind-the-i-believe-in-nashville-mural>.

¹⁴ James Pearl, *Picture this: World War I posters and visual culture*. (U of Nebraska Press, 2009).

The mural could be seen as falsifying “historical value,” as Riegl might put it, in which a particular artifact of the past is “placed before our eyes as if it were part of the present.”¹⁵ But the mural differs critically from historical value because the mural is not of the past at all. Rather, it is a contemporary object that invokes a nostalgia for a romanticized era of American history that appeals to many viewers. While it does not meet all the requirements for “pastness” according to Holtorf, in which an object looks “of the past,” it does falsify its own perceived age to some degree.¹⁶ Having the “pastness” quality enhances this mural’s legitimacy by giving the impression that many battles have been won in the city’s past simply by “believing in Nashville.” This effect is especially exacerbated when the mural is placed within the context of its many replications and parodies around the city, furthering the impression that it is some venerable symbol that has been in the public consciousness for decades.

There are three official replications of the “I Believe in Nashville” mural painted by Saporiti himself— the original at 12 South, a smaller version in East Nashville, and a wider one at Marathon Music Works (fig. 3.1-3.3). There are also plenty of parodies done by local businesses that use the original mural’s status as a famous civic symbol to market their own businesses (fig. 4.1-4.3). The main entrance of Nissan Stadium featured “I Believe in Tennessee,” displaying the colors and logo of the Tennessee Titans.¹⁷ Bridgestone Arena featured “I Believe in Smashville,” displaying the Nashville Predators’ logo and adopting their team’s vibrant yellow.¹⁸ City Pets, an animal care clinic, featured “I Believe in Petsville,”

¹⁵ Alois Riegl, “The modern cult of monuments: its essence and its development,” in *Historical and philosophical issues in the conservation of cultural heritage*, (1996): 77.

¹⁶ Cornelius Holtorf, “Perceiving the past: from age value to pastness,” *International Journal of Cultural Property* 24, no. 4 (2017): 501-504.

¹⁷ “‘I Believe In Tennessee’ Mural Debuts At Nissan Stadium,” *Nissan Stadium*, January 9, 2021, <https://nissanstadium.com/news/i-believe-in-tennessee-mural-debuts-at-nissan-stadium/>.

¹⁸ Brent Moore, “I Believe in Smashville,” *Flickr* image, April 12, 2016, https://www.flickr.com/photos/brent_nashville/25775620604.

displaying several cartoon-like pet faces lining the wall.¹⁹ Some recreations are not strategic marketing ploys but rather art that monumentalizes local events in the same vein as the original mural and the floods. “I Believe in Heroes” was an installation in Lower Broadway which featured the faces of the six police officers who risked their lives to evacuate citizens before the 2020 Nashville bombing.²⁰

Not only has “I Believe in Nashville” become such a recognizable symbol in such a short period, but it has also generated a cohesive mural landscape that advances a narrative of unity and strength in a city that need not rely on anyone else but themselves. This mural landscape is grounded in a style the average observer would interpret as being of the past, furthering the impression that these murals have seen the city triumph time and time again in the face of adversity for much longer than it has.

Ultimately, “I Believe in Nashville” presents itself as a monument of solidarity and a declaration of triumph over adversity, and the public reinforces this presentation each time the city experiences hardship. “I Believe in Nashville” murals also increase their own perceived value by falsifying age and historical significance. This has likely earned “I Believe in Nashville” the publicity it has today, but at the expense of skewed perceptions about Nashville’s history.

Saporiti could not have foreseen the widespread popularity his mural would receive. He only saw that the fresh, vibrant, red-white-blue paint contrasted well against the faded hues of the building on which it resided, an aesthetic transformation that would soon mirror, on a much

¹⁹ Theroncorse, “City Pets,” *nashville public art* blogpost, September 25, 2019, <https://nashvillepublicart.com/2019/09/25/city-pets/>.

²⁰ Rachel Wegner, “‘They ran to danger’: I Believe in Heroes mural honors officers in Nashville bombing,” *The Tennessean*, updated January 4, 2021, <https://www.tennessean.com/story/news/local/2021/01/04/nashville-bombing-i-believe-heroes-mural-downtown/4125915001/>.

larger scale, the socioeconomic transformation that would dawn on the neighborhood, thrusting “I Believe in Nashville” into a complicated relationship with the Nashvillian public.

A Monument to New Nashville

A New Tourism

“New Nashville” is often used to describe the transformation that has overcome the city in recent years.²¹ The large influx of money that has fueled Nashville’s transformation is made possible by PR campaigns carried out by civic groups to propagate certain ideas of Nashville that facilitate outside investment. One of Nashville’s largest and most successful rebranding efforts has been establishing itself as the bachelorette capital of the world. Ever since the 2000s, public art has been a critical component of this mission.

Claire Sisco King describes Nashville’s unique and wildly successful bachelorette industry as marketing a combination of “Southernness with references to celebrity culture.”²² Any Nashville bachelorette celebration employs the theme of spectacle. For example, on party buses, bachelorettes are not only offered scenic views of the city but are also put on display for the rest of the city to see (fig. 5). Party buses often “begin their tours in gentrified neighborhoods and end in Nashville’s highly trafficked downtown.”²³ Lining these routes are a number of Instagram-able sites and murals where party buses will frequently stop for bachelorettes to photograph themselves.

²¹ Nikki Burdine, “‘Old’ Nashville versus ‘New’ Nashville evident on 8th Avenue,” *WKRN*, Updated October 1, 2021, <https://www.wkrn.com/special-reports/old-nashville-versus-new-nashville-evident-on-8th-avenue/>.

²² Claire Sisco King, “‘Bach, Please’: Nashville bachelorette party culture’s investments in white Southern femininity,” *Communication and Critical/Cultural Studies* 20, no. 1 (2023): 97.

²³ *Ibid.*, 94.

Some of these murals, like Candy Hearts, located in The Gulch, were designed specifically for bachelorette party culture (fig. 6).²⁴ Its creation was sponsored by BACH (now Batch), a bachelorette party planning app. The mural features an array of hearts with references to pop culture catchphrases, marriage, getting intoxicated, and is distinctly oriented toward young women.

According to Sisco King, the effect of putting oneself out there for people to see, whether that be on lower Broadway, bachelorette-friendly murals, or social media, is that Nashville's bachelorette party culture reinforces traditional and harmful values of white southern femininity, a culture that is heavily gendered and racialized.²⁵ Lower Broadway, the epicenter of the bachelorette industry and Nashville's cultural power, is often understood as an area not particularly welcoming to black people.²⁶ Nashville bachelorette party planning service websites also feature almost exclusively white women, often with coordinated southern outfits and curled blonde hair. The same archetype is put on display on bachelorette mural hashtags on Instagram. This display stems from traditional fantasies and ideals of white southern women as beautiful, innocent, refined, and vulnerable, a position that used to justify violence against black people "for the sake of social order in the antebellum south."²⁷ Nashville's bachelorette party culture falsely markets itself as safe, when in reality this perception is rooted in the traditional image of southern white women as "needing protection," entailing that Nashville is not safe for everyone, especially black communities.²⁸ Thus, bachelorette parties in Nashville become understood as a distinctly white activity, which has the regenerative effect of propagating the same image of the

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid., 92.

²⁶ Ibid., 97.

²⁷ Ibid., 103.

²⁸ Ibid.

homogenous Nashville bachelorette party group in their various engagements in digital and physical spectacle.

The result is that Nashville's bachelorette culture sends an implicit message about who is allowed to enjoy bachelorette party culture, and by association, who can be an "ambassador to the city,"²⁹ be physically attractive, enjoy microcelebrity status,³⁰ and afford to be severely drunk in public and still qualify as a "refined lady."

"I Believe in Nashville" is no exception to propagating Nashville's bachelorette culture. The original mural at 12 south markets itself well for social media consumption. It describes what to tag in one's post and who to follow to get featured on the official page. While Saporiti did not create this mural specifically for bachelorettes, the bachelorette industry has successfully capitalized on the mural's online potential and claimed the mural for themselves (fig. 7). With tens of thousands of photos tagged #ibelieveinnashville (fig. 8), the people that circulate images of themselves at this mural the most are white women, bachelorettes, and tourists (fig. 9). As a result, the mural's presentation of itself as the icon of the entire city is merely a facade, as its overwhelming social media presence implicates Nashville as a decidedly white, tourist-driven town.

The online media presence of "I Believe in Nashville" also constructs a false image of the south, one that features not the true diversity of the modern south but instead the generally racist ideals of the antiquated south. This image of the false south advertises the idea of unity that is associated with this mural, yet paradoxically features only a certain privileged set of people. New meanings arise when considering how the bachelorettes who circulate photos of themselves here are likely out-of-town tourists who did not experience the flood. Bachelorette culture shifted the

²⁹ Ibid.

³⁰ Ibid., 92.

ownership of the mural from Nashvillian residents to the tourists, undermining people's understanding of the mural as a monument of solidarity during hardship. Thus, the original meaning behind the mural has been sacrificed for the sake of more investment in Nashville's tourist economy.

A New Public Art

The Metro Arts Commission is the mastermind behind the other side of New Nashville's rebranding campaign. Their plan is to "attract and retain creative people and enjoy the social economic benefits of their presence," which is part of an overarching goal to rebrand Nashville as "the most culturally diverse city in the south."³¹ But Jyoti Gupta explains how this plan has manifested itself in the creation of public art that only superficially celebrates the achievement of ethnic groups for the purpose of making Nashville appear more progressive, hospitable, and stable for outside investment.³²

Nashville was a pivotal city in the civil rights movement, being where a number of non-violent protests, sit-ins, and student-led demonstrations occurred. However, Nashville's rebranded identity cuts off associations with those parts of history. According to Benjamin Houston, Nashville has historically described itself as a city of "moderate race relations," where Jim Crow laws were only loosely enforced by the white elite, not out of any particular desire to be progressive or moral, but out of the fear that being extreme or causing civil unrest would disrupt the gentle southern etiquette Nashville so desperately wanted to profess.³³ This legacy

³¹ Jenifer Cole & Craige Hoover, "Arts and Culture," *nashvillenext*, March 2013, 14; *Ibid.*, 16.

³² Jyoti Gupta, "Civic pivot: Smoothing the politics of race and place through arts and culture in Nashville, Tennessee," *Journal of Urban Affairs* 44, no. 4-5 (2022): 755.

³³ Benjamin Houston, "The Nashville Way: racial etiquette and the struggle for social justice in a southern city," (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2012), 1-6; *Ibid.*, 6.

has carried on into Nashville's public art sphere in the 21st century, which has become a tool to rebrand Nashville as a town that is and always has been polite, socially progressive, and possessing favorable race relations.³⁴ In reality, Gupta discusses how Nashville has smoothed over histories of racial tension with superficial public art that is "empty and self-serving" to the white elite, giving the impression of progressivism that would make Nashvillian public life more marketable to outside investment.³⁵

Metro Arts sponsors public art projects that present Nashville as somehow past the era of racial struggle and thus a secure place for investment, but in doing so, obscures the real issues of racial tensions in the city today. Nashville has falsified its own history for economic gain, and in the process made it harder to confront systemic racial issues. The commodification of race and public life characterizes modern practices of neoliberal multiculturalism, in which celebrating and marketing diversity has taken precedence over achieving equal opportunity and racial equality. These practices "turn on rhetoric of diversity, racial and ethnic inclusion, and 'tolerance' to stimulate real estate investments by a progressively-minded cohort while eliding the intrinsic importance of these values."³⁶

For example, only as recently as 2017 did Nashville unveil its first civil rights memorial, Witness Walls (fig. 10). While the memorial depicts the sit-ins, protests, and real scenes of racial struggle in civil-rights era Nashville, the ultimate motive behind the art was made clear when Mayor Megan Barry, in a speech during the grand unveiling of the artwork, referred to it as an indication that Nashville is reflecting on its racial past, making the art a boon for economic

³⁴ Gupta, "Civic pivot," 761.

³⁵ Ibid., 763.

³⁶ Ibid., 750.

development.³⁷ Witness Walls, while a relatively confrontational piece of art that evokes Nashville's lesser-known past, is ultimately an economic ploy.

"I Believe in Nashville," while not directly commissioned by Metro Arts, shares many of the same characteristics as Metro Arts projects — namely, the endorsement of a false but attractive narrative of Nashville that would boost the city's economic potential. Its connection to Metro Arts' economic philosophy could be a reason why the icon has enjoyed so much publicity among parts of the public and major local corporations. The mural celebrates the faith of a unified public in their city able to overcome hardship, but masks deeper issues about Nashvillian redevelopment, notably, that Nashvillian prosperity is a luxury unavailable to many residents.

12 South used to be considered an affordable neighborhood and home to a substantial black population. Since the turn of the century, however, there has been a significant exodus of this black community, and in its place, an affluent white community, expensive restaurants, high-end boutiques, houses well out of the previous population's price range, and finally, "I Believe in Nashville" (fig. 11.1-11.2).³⁸ A similar process is happening in East Nashville, another place once considered affordable and now home to another "I Believe in Nashville" mural. Each time disaster strikes, in the 1998 tornado, 2010 flood, and 2020 tornado, the land is wiped clean, developers buy destroyed lots, and a new wave of gentrification begins.³⁹ In other words, "I Believe in Nashville" are the words of the new affluent community, not the long-time residents it displaced.

³⁷ Megan Barry, "Witness Walls Dedication Ceremony," YouTube video filmed in April 21, 2017, April 24, 2017, 44:02, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L-Q2-MR1a2Q>.

³⁸ Eli Motycka, "Churches Go Last: An Influx of Wealth Has Remade 12South," *Nashville Scene*, June 30, 2022, https://www.nashvillescene.com/news/coverstory/churches-go-last-an-influx-of-wealth-has-remade-12south/article_2ba309c8-f657-11ec-91f2-c3dc4c95dcec.html.

³⁹ Honest Lewis, "Floods and Gentrification: Lessons from Nashville," *Medium*, August 31, 2017, <https://medium.com/@honestlewis/floods-and-gentrification-lessons-from-nashville-1373671deabb>.

The mural attempts to smooth the tensions that arise from gentrification by asserting that all the people of Nashville are united because they have a shared history — the flood. Yet this obscures the reality of the situation that the recovery effort of Nashville’s natural disasters are never equal. It places the blame of displacement firmly on the flood itself and not how the city redeveloped. In the end, the mural helps brand Nashville as a city united and unshaken by disaster, which belies the reality that Nashville is becoming an increasingly exclusive city and that this cultural icon is sponsored by the new and wealthy.

Nashville’s bachelorette culture rebranding campaign comes hand in hand with the forces of gentrification, a process visible in 12 South. Saporiti originally painted the mural on an empty building facing a parking lot. Today, the mural faces the wall of actress Reese Witherspoon’s Draper James store, a high-end women’s clothing line that “honors her southern heritage” and grandparents from whom she “learned to dress and act like a lady.”⁴⁰ The mural sits on the wall of the 12 South Dental Studio, a business that advertises purely cosmetic dental procedures.⁴¹ Even the name “12 South” was an act of rebranding the street to separate itself from the historical 12th Avenue South and its associations as being a “rough area.”⁴² The transformation of 12 South from a working-class neighborhood to an affluent region for tourists are the scenes of New Nashville, a city that falsifies its identity for rapid but unequal growth.

The result of these rebranding campaigns is that rather than have public art represent the voices of the city projected onto urban space, making way for challenging commentary on public life, mural art like “I Believe in Nashville” advances the image of Nashville as unified, safe, and progressive, and simultaneously obscures a history of racial tension, gentrification, and harmful

⁴⁰ Reese Witherspoon, “Welcome to Draper James,” <https://draperjames.com/pages/about-draper-james>.

⁴¹ “Services | 12 South Dental Studio,” <https://www.12southdentalstudio.com/services>. Invisalign, botox and cosmetic veneers are the three main services advertised.

⁴² Motycka, “Churches Go Last.”

notions of gender.

A Monument to a Divisive Society

In the summer of 2017, the 12 South “I Believe in Nashville” mural was vandalized. The vandals painted a globe in place of the Tennessee tristar and changed the text to “I Believe in Global Warming” (fig. 12).⁴³ The event was widely reported on by the news, and on Facebook, a large amount of debate was stirred. Conversations were characterized by unanimous disapproval, name-calling, and suggestions for more severe forms of punishment.⁴⁴ But no one talked about the content of the vandalism itself. No one commented on global warming, either advocating for or downplaying it, only that this precious icon was disrespected and the suspects should be punished. In other words, the conversation that the vandals tried to start completely eluded the public.

The vandals were drawing attention to the other side to the 2010 floods, an event described by the USGS as a 1000-year flood, occurring only once a millennium.⁴⁵ But the reality is that these floods are becoming increasingly common due to climate change. In the summer of 2022, in only the span of a month, there were six 1000-year floods recorded in the US.⁴⁶ “I Believe in Nashville” makes a statement about what humans have control of, which is the recovery effort, not the flood itself. The act of vandalism takes a critical stance from this

⁴³ Kaylin Searles, Katie Grunik & Erika Lathon, “Police: Suspect defaced “I Believe in Nashville” mural with global warming message,” *Fox 17 Nashville*, July 25, 2017, <https://fox17.com/news/local/i-believe-in-nashville-mural-in-12south-vandalized-again>.

⁴⁴ WSMV 4 Nashville, “BREAKING: Caleb Jones, 20, and Breanna Lesch, 20, were both charged with felony vandalism last night,” *Facebook* post, July 28, 2017, <https://www.facebook.com/WSMVTV/posts/breaking-caleb-jones-20-and-breanna-lesch-20-were-both-charged-with-felony-vanda/10155043678431715/>.

⁴⁵ “May 2010 Flood,” National Weather Service.

⁴⁶ Alan Urban, “1000-Year Floods Have Become Disturbingly Common,” *Medium*, July 14, 2023, <https://medium.com/@CollapseSurvival/1000-year-floods-have-become-disturbingly-common-c66344d4bc9b#:~:text=Last%20summer%2C%20six%201000%2Dyear,rain%20in%20just%20three%20hours>.

perspective and indicates that “I Believe in Nashville” is merely a superficial message that does not call for concrete action.

This mural, and the conversations surrounding it, carefully avoid politicization and conflict. The aforementioned “modern southern etiquette” and neoliberal multiculturalism practices that have characterized Nashville’s identity are reflected here, where immediate solutions and superficial celebrations are favored over discussions about long-term, material change, and any social tensions are concealed under a guise of unity and solidarity, or to take it literally in this case, a fresh new layer of paint.

The non-confrontational nature of “I Believe in Nashville” is a quality preserved in replications as well (fig. 13). “I Believe in California” was a shirt designed by Rich Egan to raise awareness and money for the 2018 California wildfires.⁴⁷ This shirt also advocates for static ideas like resilience and solidarity over concrete solutions. Wildfires in California, like floods in Tennessee, are also becoming increasingly frequent due to climate change. “I Believe in Heroism” was another shirt designed to celebrate James Shaw Jr., the man who tackled and disarmed the Nashville Waffle House shooter, likely saving several lives.⁴⁸ This shirt advocates the idea of “heroes,” an abstract idea that does not suggest material change, but a statement that would be difficult to spark controversy or politicization. It chooses not to take a stance on how to confront gun violence itself through policy or social change, but instead opts for a superficial and non-confrontational subject. This non-confrontational quality of “I Believe in Nashville” products thrives particularly well for commodification in the postmodern economy.

⁴⁷ Amanda, “I Believe in California” charity shirt from “I Believe in Nashville” team,” *Nashville Music Guide*, November 12, 2018, <https://nashvillemusicguide.com/i-believe-in-california-charity-shirt-from-i-believe-in-nashville-team/>.

⁴⁸ “I Believe in Nashville,” *Hargi’s Studio*, <https://www.hargisstudio.com/ibelieveinnashville>.

Postmodernism has affected the way the public distributes and interacts with art, often characterized as emphasizing style over substance. Fredric Jameson discusses this phenomenon of increasingly depthless art as a symptom of postmodernism that markets itself well for commodification.⁴⁹ “I Believe in Nashville” is depthless not only in the physical sense but in terms of its textual content as well. The icon exemplifies what Jameson might call “postmodern pastiche,” art that mimics another style but offers no commentary or critique, unlike parody.⁵⁰ As a result, the past is understood today as nothing more than a set of commodifiable styles. Due to the “waning of our historicity,” modern society has become “increasingly incapable of fashioning representations of our own current experience.”⁵¹ “I Believe in Nashville” has taken the nostalgic Americana aesthetic of the previous century and distilled it down to a strict formula by which future reproductions can be made for any event — a famous person, holiday, current event, or even just a general concept. But these reproductions offer little commentary about these events beyond merely noting their existence. The official “I Believe in Nashville” Instagram page, not affiliated with Saporiti, is a machine that repeatedly regenerates and sells these empty styles on a regular basis. “I Believe in Nashville” even had its own brewery,⁵² also not affiliated with Saporiti, which sold beer cans featuring the icon. These mass-produced products derive their success from their association with a famous cultural icon and their superficiality, which has made them malleable across many contexts.

While “I Believe in Nashville” represents a postmodern pastiche of a nostalgic historical aesthetic, the postmodern economy has even cannibalized the mural itself,⁵³ turning it into a

⁴⁹ Fredric Jameson, *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*, (New York, USA: Duke University Press, 1992), 396, <https://doi-org.proxy.library.vanderbilt.edu/10.1515/9780822378419>.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, 16.

⁵¹ *Ibid.*, 21.

⁵² *I Believe Brewing Co*, <https://ibelievebrewing.com/>.

⁵³ Fredric Jameson, *Postmodernism*, 276.

recipe for quick and easy commemorations. Whether it be present online, on a shirt, or on a drink, the sheer amount of these copies almost seem to mock the comparative sincerity of Saporiti's original mural (fig. 14).

In solidarity with the Black Lives Matter movement, the I Believe in Nashville Instagram page posted an "I Believe in Unity" design featuring a white and black hand shaking.⁵⁴ For MLK day, they posted "I Believe in Dreams," with MLK's face in the center. During the start of COVID, they began giving away "I Believe in Hope" masks, and just three months later posted "I Believe in Science," two contradictory statements that reflect how the American public's views on the COVID pandemic response changed in its early months. But it also shows how the postmodern market promotes saleable art motivated by little desire to advocate change beyond what is already unanimously endorsed at the time.

These images produce an impression of unity, but paradoxically also represent how American society and beliefs have polarized and fragmented to the point where these empty images are the only things that enjoy widespread support. Nashville writer Steve Haruch calls the mural "hideously self-congratulatory."⁵⁵ This mural landscape of "I Believe in Nashvilles" on the streets of Nashville and on people's social media feeds almost creates a hypnotic effect, as if it were trying to persuade one of its message rather than display a known sentiment.

Chloe Stillwell, a longtime Nashville resident, comments on how the city, commonly referred to as a "blue island in a sea of red," has become more conservative in recent decades. Compared with other urban areas in the US, Nashville is nearly dead center on its public's

⁵⁴ (@ibelieveinnashville), *Instagram Page*, <https://www.instagram.com/ibelieveinnashville/>.

⁵⁵ Steve Haruch, *Greetings from New Nashville: How a Sleepy Southern Town Became "it" City*. (Vanderbilt University Press, 2020), 17.

political leaning.⁵⁶ This means designing an agreeable icon for a population as divided as Nashville would be a near impossible task if it were to address current and political issues with material solutions. “I Believe in Nashville” represents the city’s closest civic icon to enjoying city-wide support, displaying vague ideas about unity and strength with no clear pathway on how this should be achieved. Thus, it is an unimpeachable icon. While the widespread prevalence of this mural in the public sphere might indicate unity and cohesion in Nashville, the irony is that this is merely a facade that conceals the real divisions and tensions undergirding Nashville’s population.

Conclusion

Conventional wisdom will often have that Nashville derived its famous nickname, “Music City,” from the Grand Ole Opry country radio show that used to sign off “Live from Music City USA in the 1960s.”⁵⁷ Or, if opting for a more socially progressive narrative, some credit the Fisk Jubilee Singers in 1871 as impressing Queen Victoria so much she said they must have come from a “city of music.”⁵⁸ The reality is that “Music City” was not an organic nickname arising from local folklore but a calibrated rebranding effort. In the 1990s, with country music losing interest nationwide and Nashville’s economy entering a recession, it urgently needed a rebranding that would attract entrepreneurial investment. In a 2003 meeting with 150 business executives, they decided on “Music City” as *the* brand that would expand its

⁵⁶ Chloe Stillwell, “What Nashville is Now,” *Slate*, June 11, 2021, <https://slate.com/business/2021/06/nashville-political-transformation-gigi-gaskins.html>; Drew Desilver, “The most liberal and conservative big cities,” *Pew Research Center*, August 8, 2014, <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2014/08/08/chart-of-the-week-the-most-liberal-and-conservative-big-cities/>.

⁵⁷ “WSM - Since 1925,” *WSM Radio*, <https://wsradio.com/history/>

⁵⁸ Staff, “Why is Nashville called Music City? The Fisk Jubilee Singers and Queen Victoria get the credit,” *The Tennessean*, February 19, 2019, <https://www.tennessean.com/story/life/2019/02/19/why-nashville-called-music-city/2906635002/>

associations with just country music to include all types of music, and thus this was the label that was forcefully disseminated to the Nashville public from the top-down.⁵⁹

Nashville has been wildly successful at conveying to outsiders its invented reputation as a polite, historical, and fun city, but Bruce Barry, commenting on what these facades obscure, said “a tourism brand isn’t a city, and a mid-sized city with significant crime, inferior transit, unexceptional public education, and a stubbornly regressive cultural climate isn’t a world class city.”⁶⁰

While “I Believe in Nashville” did not originate as a bureaucratic ploy to boost Nashville’s economy, the icon has been adopted into multiple domains for their own self-serving purposes. The public has stretched and shaped its meaning to fit a number of narratives, turning “I Believe in Nashville” into a masquerade with indeterminate and variable meanings. Each of these domains that lay claim to “I Believe in Nashville” use the icon to advance narratives of Nashville as a safe, unified, and loyal city with a rich history, while simultaneously concealing its invented histories, racial tensions, harmful notions of southern hospitality and safety, and disunity among the public.

When the day broke on March 3, 2020, as people continued circulating images of the destroyed Basement East with the intact “I Believe in Nashville” mural as a divine sign of strength, the city came to life and went straight to rebuilding (fig. 15). But out on the devastated landscape, Land Rovers circulated the streets with speculators offering lowball cash offers to buy the property off of people who just lost their homes, many of whom were uninsured.⁶¹ For many

⁵⁹ Philip Powell, Timothy Slaper & Carol Rogers, “Music City and the Circle City: Lessons for regional economic development strategy,” *Indiana Business Review*, 2023, <https://www.ibrc.indiana.edu/ibr/2023/spring/article1.html>.

⁶⁰ Bruce Barry, “A tale of two cities,” *Tennessee Lookout*, January 30, 2023, <https://tennesseelookout.com/2023/01/30/a-tale-of-two-cities/>

⁶¹ Richard Fausset and Steve Cavendish, “A Tornado Decimated North Nashville. The Rebuilding May Destroy Its Soul,” *The New York Times*, March 4, 2020, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/03/04/us/tennessee-tornado.html>;

locals, the promise of redevelopment that the surviving “I Believe in Nashville” mural signifies isn’t an optimistic symbol of hope, but a threat.

Nickelle Smith, “North Nashville recovery progresses two years after March 2020 tornado,” *WKRN*, March 3, 2022, <https://www.wkrn.com/news/nashville-tornado/north-nashville-recovery-progresses-two-years-after-march-2020-tornado/#:~:text=After%20the%20storm%20hit%20there,financial%20needs%20of%20tornado%20victims>.

Illustrations



Figure 1. Destroyed Basement East after tornado. Photograph by Brett Carlsen/Getty Images North America, March 3, 2020, *CNN*, <https://www.cnn.com/2020/03/03/us/nashville-tornado-mural-trnd/index.html>.



Figure 2: I Believe in Nashville mural at 12 South. Photograph by Alec Cheng, March 11, 2024, 12 South, Nashville.

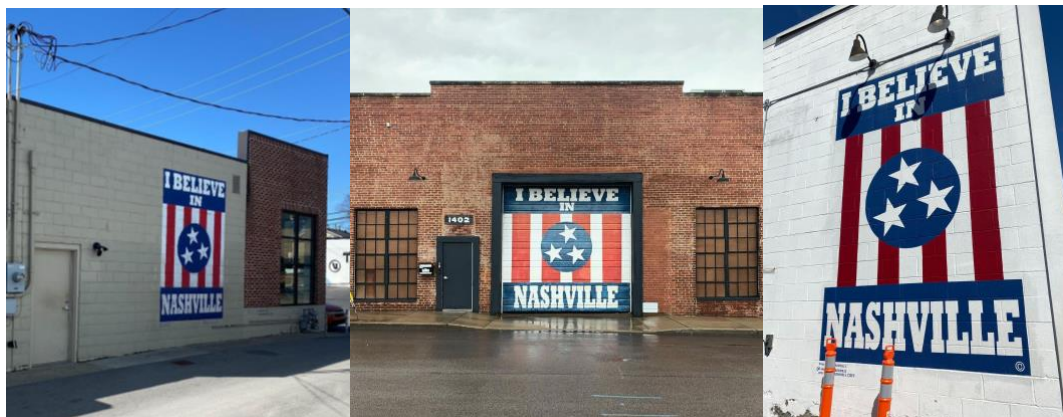


Figure 3.1 (left): I Believe in Nashville mural at 12 South's Howell's Alley. Photograph by Alec Cheng, March 11, 2024, 12 South, Nashville.

Figure 3.2 (middle): I Believe in Nashville mural at Marathon Music Works. Photograph by @jbtakesnash, *NashvilleGo*, April 5, 2021, 1402 Clinton St, Nashville. <https://nashvillego.com/activities/marathon-music-works>.

Figure 3.3 (right): I Believe in Nashville mural at The Basement East. Photograph by Alec Cheng, March 11, 2024, The Basement East, East Nashville.

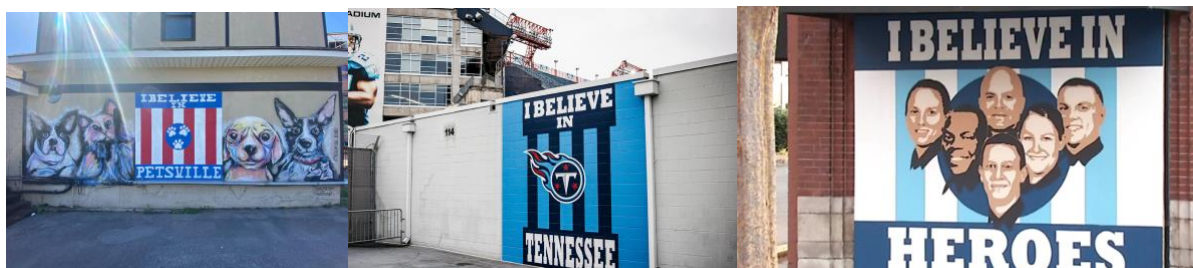


Figure 4.1 (left): I Believe in Petsville mural at City Pets. Photograph by Alec Cheng, March 11, 2024, City Pets Animal Care, Nashville.

Figure 4.2 (middle): I Believe in Tennessee mural at Nissan Stadium entrance. Photograph by @NissanStadium, January 9, 2021, Nissan Stadium, Nashville. <https://nissanstadium.com/news/i-believe-in-tennessee-mural-debuts-at-nissan-stadium/>.

Figure 4.3 (right): I Believe in Heroes mural at 2nd Avenue and Broadway. Photograph by Fox 17 News, *Fox 17 News*, 2021, Lower Broadway, Nashville. <https://fox17.com/news/local/mural-honors-nashville-police-officers-who-ran-to-danger-saved-people-before-bombing-christmas-explosion-i-believe-in-heroes>.



Figure 5: *Downtown Nashville on a typical night*, Photograph by John Partipilo, *Tennessee Lookout*, 2023, Lower Broadway, Nashville.

<https://tennesseelookout.com/2023/01/30/a-tale-of-two-cities/>.



Figure 6: *Candy Hearts Photoshoot*, Photography by Mandy Liz Photography, *flamesmedia*, Candy Hearts, The Gulch, Nashville.

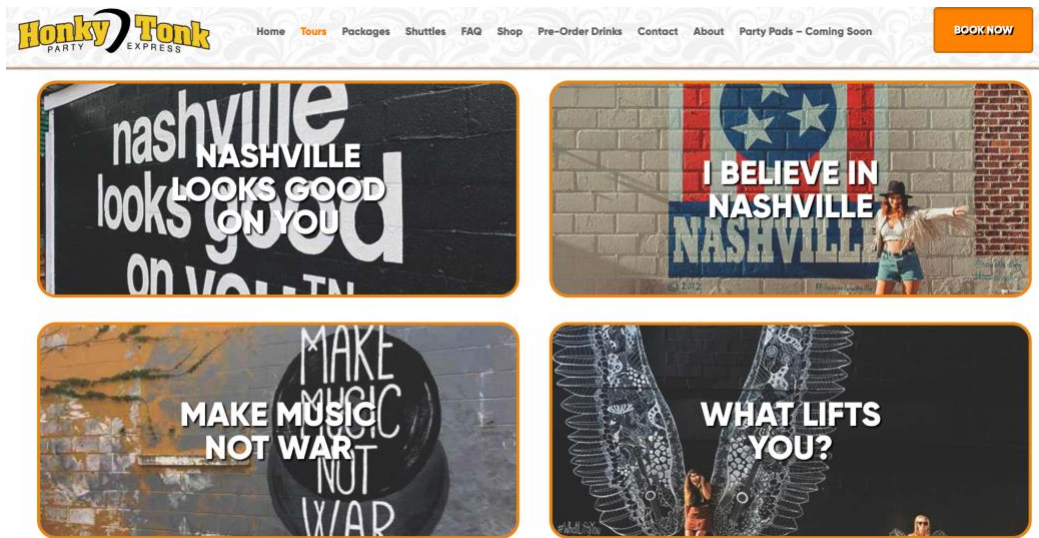


Figure 7: Screenshot of Honky Tonk Party Express mural tour services, *Honky Tonk Party Express* Website, Nashville.

<https://honkytonkpartyexpress.com/nashville-mural-bus/>



Figure 8: Screenshot of #ibelieveinnashville posts, *Instagram*, Posts from 2023.



Figure 9: People standing in front of 12 South Mural, Photograph taken by Alec Cheng, March 11, 2024, 12 South, Nashville.



Figure 10: *Witness Walls*, Photograph by Metro Arts, Artwork by Walter Hood, *Metro Arts*, Completed 2017, 1 Public Sq, Nashville.
<https://www.metroartsnashville.com/witness-walls?pgid=k5wwxb7t-bcd73fd9-bc19-4369-aa61-858316572d6c>.



Figure 11.1 (top): Howell's Alley in 2011, Google maps photo of July 2011, Howell's Alley Facebook, Posted October 19, 2023, 12 South, Nashville,
<https://www.facebook.com/photo/?fbid=829386528887871&set=pcb.829387098887814>.

Figure 11.2 (bottom): Howell's Alley in 2023, Photograph by Morgan Lindsay Photography, *retailtouchpoints*, 12 South, Nashville,
<https://www.google.com/url?q=https://www.retailtouchpoints.com/topics/omnichannel-alignment/draper-james-majority-sale&sa=D&source=docs&ust=1713340595368396&usg=AOvVaw2Peih26RuVFpfLuUcq-OYI>.



Figure 12: I Believe in Nashville mural vandalized to I Believe in Global Warming, Photograph by Fox 17 News, *Fox 17 News*, July 25, 2017, 12 South, Nashville, <https://fox17.com/news/local/gallery/i-believe-in-nashville-mural-in-12south-vandalized-again?photo=1>.



Figure 13: Imitations of I Believe in Nashville shirts for sale, Photograph by Hargis Studio, *Hargis Studio*, <https://www.hargisstudio.com/ibelieveinnashville>.

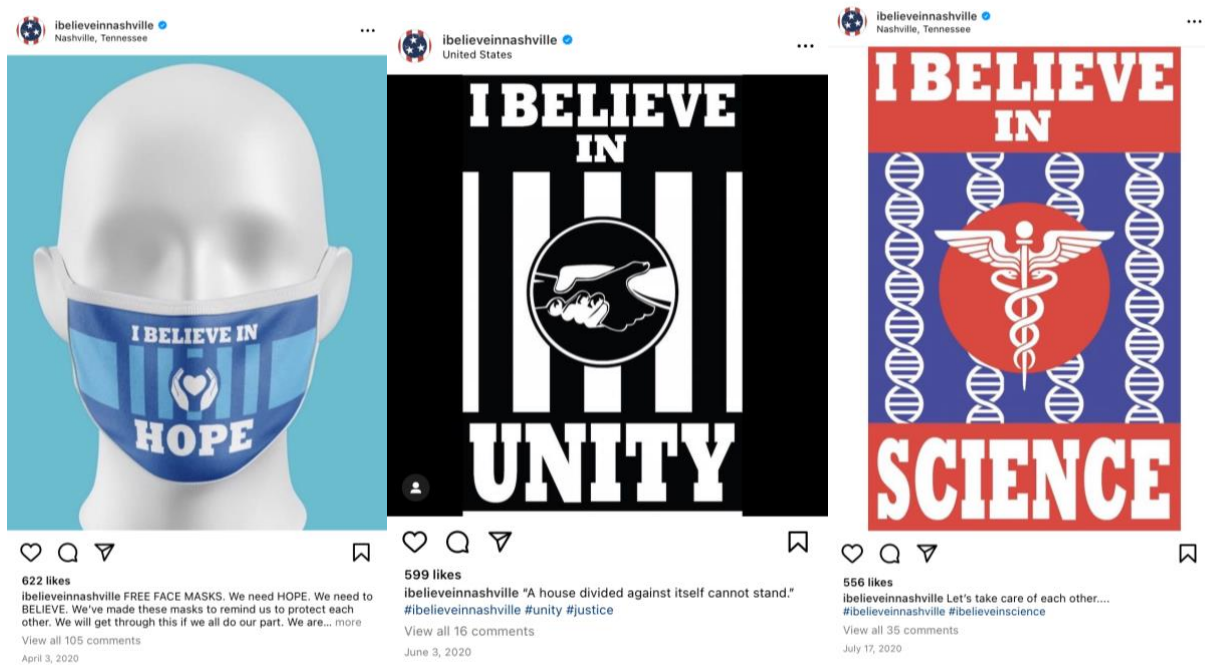


Figure 14: I Believe in Nashville imitations on the official Instagram, Screenshot from Instagram, *Instagram*, Photos from 2020, <https://www.instagram.com/ibelieveinnashville/>.

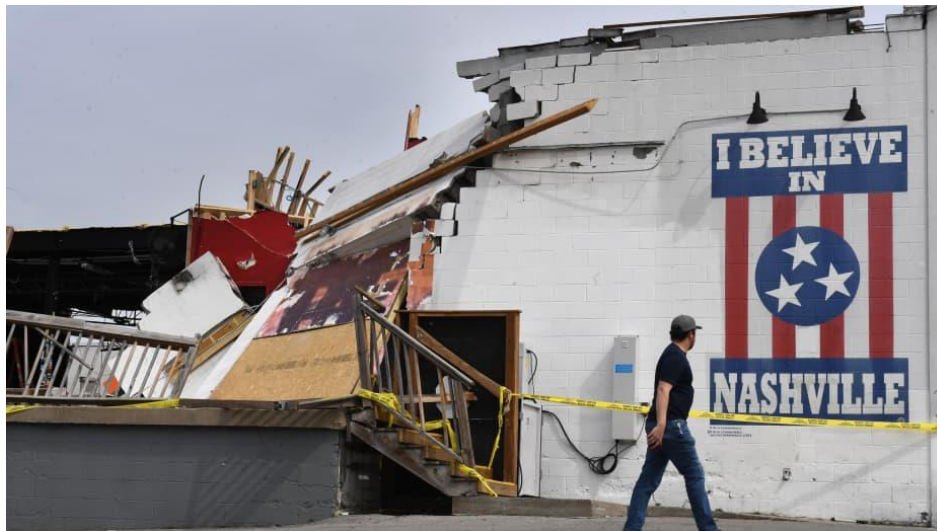


Figure 15: I Believe in Nashville mural on destroyed Basement East, Photograph by Matt McClain/The Washington Post Via Getty Images, *Soundslikenashville*, March 3, 2021, The Basement East, East Nashville, <https://www.soundslikenashville.com/news/basement-east-reopening-nashville-tornado/>.

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<https://www.facebook.com/WSMVTV/posts/breaking-caleb-jones-20-and-breanna-lesch-20-were-both-charged-with-felony-vanda/10155043678431715/>.